

were instructed to keep themselves separate from their Babylonian neighbors by observing strict rules of diet and cleanliness. (The Hebrew word *qadosh*, translated as “holy,” literally means “separate.”) It was common in the ancient world for priests to observe rules of purity. Egyptian priests, for example, had to bathe in cold water four times a day and wear papyrus sandals and linen rather than leather or wool. But the idea that a whole nation should follow such laws was unique.

The Jewish rules and rituals are described in detail. Leviticus 11:47 commands the people to distinguish “between the unclean and the clean, between living creatures that may be eaten and those that may not be eaten.” Pork, shellfish, and many other foods were forbidden. Those animals that were permitted could be eaten only if they were ritually slaughtered and the blood removed. According to Leviticus 11:39, “If an animal that you are allowed to eat dies, anyone who touches its carcass will be unclean till evening.”

Leviticus 14:48–53 describes an elaborate ceremony to purify a house with mold on the walls. A priest should take cedar wood, scarlet yarn,

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Speak to the entire assembly
of Israel and say to them:

Be holy, because I,
the Lord your God,
am holy.

Leviticus 19:1–2

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hyssop, and a live bird; dip them into the blood of a sacrificed bird and some fresh water; and sprinkle the house seven times. “Then he is to release the live bird in the open fields outside the town. In this way he will make atonement for the house, and it will be clean.”

Absolute truth

Earlier ancient law codes, such as the Code of Hammurabi, were casuistic—describing procedure in particular cases, from which general principles were derived. In contrast, the Ten Commandments were

apodictic—absolute statements of right and wrong, such as “You shall not murder.” Even so, the Mosaic code included many laws that resembled Mesopotamian and Babylonian laws. For example, law 251 in Hammurabi’s code states, “If an ox be a goring ox, and it shown that he is a gorer, and [the owner] do not bind his horns, or fasten the ox up, and the ox gore a free-born man and kill him, the owner shall pay one-half a mina in money.” Exodus 21:29–30 says that if a bull “has had the habit of goring and the owner has been warned but has not kept it penned up and it kills a man or woman, the bull is to be stoned and its owner also is to be put to death. However ... the owner may redeem his life by the payment of whatever is demanded.”

Although Mesopotamian kings claimed to rule on behalf of gods, they never claimed that their gods were themselves the authors of the laws. To break a law was to commit an offense against a fellow human, who might choose to pardon the offender. But breaking a law in the Torah was different: it was not just an offense against a fellow human, it was also a sin against God. ■



Reading from the Torah scroll is part of the ritual of Jewish prayers. It takes place on certain days, including the Sabbath and Jewish holidays.

The Torah scroll

The scroll that contains the text of the Torah—including the laws given by God to Moses—is the most sacred object in every Jewish synagogue. Each scroll, or *Sefer Torah* (*sefer* means “book” or “written document”), is handwritten on special parchment using a traditional quill or reed. The text contains 304,805 Hebrew letters, which have to be written perfectly by a trained scribe. A single mistake would invalidate the entire scroll.

The scroll is kept in a richly ornamented cabinet called the Torah ark. The holiest part of the synagogue and the focal point of prayer, this is built on the wall facing Jerusalem.

Passages from the Torah scroll are read out in the synagogue, usually several times a week. Selected sections are read every Sabbath morning, chosen so that the entire Torah is read over the course of a year. The end of this annual cycle is marked by the festival of *Simchat Torah*.